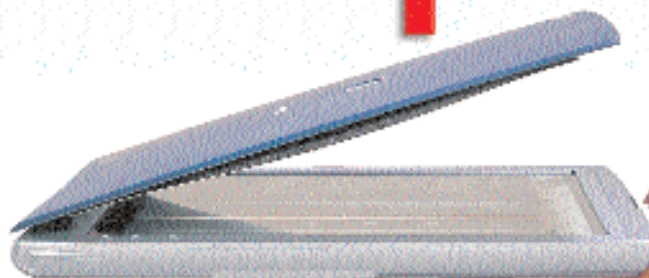


Higher and Sharper



More than 20 scanners strut confidently out of the market, and into our test lab, with features and performance that will impress, and prices that will astound. Which model has the right stuff? Hang around for a clear picture

Not too long ago, scanners were bulky peripherals occupying much desk space, while the scanning resolution remained at 600 dpi. This was the time when price was the crucial deciding factor, and scanning was still a dabbling practise and not a necessary function.

Today, even entry-level scanners can spin their magic at well over 1200 dpi and are infinitely more affordable, not to mention slim, good looking and admirably good at multitasking. A scanner can, for example, acquire a document and e-mail or print it, or even burn a copy of it on a CD—all in a matter of moments. It has, thus, been elevated to the status of a smart companion from just a mono-task device. Moreover, technology such as

Contact Image Sensors (CIS) provides a scanner with a space-saving design, without sacrificing on quality.

Although scanners are not on the list of hardware to see major technological changes, these devices are now capable of performing at a hardware resolution of 2400 x 4800 dpi, and at 48-bit colour depth. Subtle changes in the way sensors are built, have also helped the scanner reproduce better results in less time.

The fall in prices has made it easy for manufacturers to embellish the scanner with accessories—Transparency adapters and Automatic Document Feeders are two such add-ons. The market is flooded with different brands, competing fiercely for the attention of the end user. The battle is fought on the grounds